

guest column

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THE RACISM ROW

The match referee's unfair verdict on Harbhajan Singh was expected as he is biased towards whites



The morale of the Indian team would have slumped in Sydney after the erroneous decision-making in the second Test, but now, with the removal of Steve Bucknor from the next Test at Perth, at least, one of their problems has been solved. BCCI has done a commendable job in getting Bucknor ousted so quickly, especially since the Australians have so much clout in the International Cricket Council (ICC). This control over the ruling authority is probably the reason why the umpires, who are dependent on ICC for their jobs, have that additional pressure to be fair to the Aussies. They must also believe that since Australia is the champion team, and play cricket the hard way, they must always be right.

Australians traditionally like to divert the opposition's attention; that is their speciality. And against the champions, you cannot afford to lose focus for a second. I feel this whole racism row is another diversionary tactic employed by them. For instance, looking back to the Mumbai episode, if somebody from the crowd was shouting, Andrew Symonds should have told officials about it and got the concerned offenders removed instead of creating a hue and cry. This current controversy too should have been resolved more amicably. Certain things happen on long tours, but that does not mean dirty linen should be washed in public.

Having said that, the judgement on the racism charges against Harbhajan Singh has been extremely unfair to India. The Indian cricket board has to make sure the penalty is revoked, because there is no basis for it. In fact, BCCI should have taken the advantage of the presence of Sunil Gavaskar, who is already there at the venue as a commentator, and has first-hand information about what has been brewing. He could have been authorised to tackle the matter on behalf of India, especially since he is in the high powered committee of BCCI. He is also the chairman of the ICC technical committee. One wonders why BCCI did not make use of such a great opportunity. Now, when the commissioner is ap-

pointed and the inquiry is fixed, then both sides will have adequate representation. The Indian cricket board should ensure they present a strong view on Harbhajan's case.

The on-field officials had admitted that they had not heard anything and in the absence of any other evidence, how could the match referee take Ricky Ponting's word for it? He is bound to support his own players, just like he supported Michael Clarke about the bump catch. By ignoring the word of Sachin Tendulkar, who has a better standing than Ponting, he is questioning the Indian's credibility. It is a one-sided judgement, and I must say that I have always experienced that with Mike Procter. He has always supported men with white skin, and pulled up players from India and Sri Lanka. This decision has been biased too.

Cricket, however, is bigger than any individual, and I am glad the series is going to go on.

REUTERS



BIAS: Mike Procter has a racial history

The exclusion of Bucknor was crucial because, after the Sydney game, the Indian team would have been left feeling that decisions at important junctures could easily go against them. The West Indian has been giving poor decisions for quite some time now, and while cricket boards have no authority over the appointment of permanent umpires or referees, I feel BCCI should have at least lodged a protest at the time he was named for the series. Why take a chance? ICC should also monitor the performance of the umpires they are appointing. They cannot be emotional and continue with umpires just for sentimental reasons. Really, if the fate of the

match is dependent on umpiring decisions as opposed to cricketing skills, it is very sad.

As it is, even without the umpiring problems, the pressure would have been tremendous on the visitors. They were playing the world champions, on their own turf, without much practice and with the knowledge that the crowds as well as the press would be totally behind their home team. Hats off to Ganguly and company for almost pulling off a series win the last time they toured Australia.

The author is a former Indian cricketer and was coach of the national team from 1997 to 1999.